

Score Keyword Relevance by Co-Ranking Overlap, Then Forecast the Revenue

Let Google score your keyword list for you — the phrases the top 10 ranking URLs all co-rank for are the relevant ones — then run the survivors through to a revenue number.

Source: **Jeremy Rivera**, founder, SEO Arcade — guest on the Unscripted SEO Interview Podcast, hosted by Mark A Preston.

OBJECTIVE

Produce two ranked keyword lists and one revenue forecast from a single seed set, using co-ranking overlap as the relevance score. Pull the pages already ranking for your seeds, export everything **those** pages rank for, stack it all in one sheet and count the duplicates. A phrase ten of ten ranking URLs share is a phrase Google has already connected to your core term. The rare phrases become your long-tail list. Then human-check the SERPs, strip the terms you are forbidden to chase, rate each survivor by distance to conversion, and run the list through volume → CTR → conversion → sale rate → revenue per sale.

"And then lightning struck my brain and I said, that's the signal. That's how I can tell that Google sees the overlap." — Jeremy Rivera

KEY STEPS

- 1 Pick one to five seed keywords, not one.**
"You have a single seed keyword. Actually, I bumped it up to five." Near-synonyms return genuinely different universes: "'natural HVAC' and 'natural air conditioning,' 'natural heating' and 'natural cooling' — they're going to have a different matrix, a different universe of keywords."
- 2 Take the top 10 ranking URLs per seed, then export the top 100 keywords each of those URLs ranks for.**
"Look at those top 10 URLs, go and download a CSV of the top 100 keywords that those pages rank for." Any rank-data source with a per-URL keyword export works. Do all ten URLs for every seed, not the convenient three.
- 3 Stack every export into one sheet and count the duplicates — the duplicate count IS the score.**
Do not de-duplicate. Add a count column and sort descending. "If for this particular phrase 10 out of 10 URLs all co-rank for one of those phrases, that is a higher priority, that is more relevant to the core phrase." Expect 500–1,000 rows: "it usually is somewhere between 500 and a thousand keywords that you're looking at."
- 4 Flip the sort. The bottom of the list is your second deliverable.**
"What are the terms and phrases that just one of our competitors really does well for? And boom, there you go, longtail research." A count of one is either a strong domain's unrelated deep cut (discard) or an unclaimed opening nobody in the set has covered (cheapest content you will build all quarter).
- 5 Do the human pass on the SERP. Mandatory, not optional.**
"There is no tool that's going to be able to look at this list and tell that — you have to go to the SERP, you need to look at that term, plug it in and see, how is Google recognizing that term or phrase?" Hunt false positives (another business or region with the same name) and split intent: "It's like Nashville air conditioning — the traffic is higher than any other phrase, because half of the people want to buy an air conditioner, half of the people want air conditioning service... and you've got to split that traffic in two intuitively."
- 6 Build the negative keyword list — and get the client to vet it BEFORE you build anything.**
*"You've got to get your keyword list vetted by your client. You've got to find out your negative SEO keywords. In PPC, half of the job is figuring out what not to bid on, and SEOs on the regular miss this step." Three sources of red lines: legal history, YMYL claim restrictions ("there are red lines of terms and phrases left and right, of claims that you cannot make"), and banned brand phrases. Each gets one of two dispositions — cross it off entirely, or **rank negative**: use it in a context that shows up for the term while stating you are not that term.*
- 7 Add a "distance to conversion" column and rate every survivor.**
"Have an empty column for you to rate: how close to conversion is this keyword? Because there are people who are searching for a term or phrase, and yeah, that page ranks for it and it's relevant, but they're not really ever going to buy it. Or, hey, that's my money term." This column is what stops a high-volume phrase that never converts from driving the forecast.

KEY STEPS (CONTINUED)

8 Run the surviving list through the five-stage forecast.

Take monthly volume, apply a position-based organic CTR curve, multiply by conversion rate for leads, by lead-to-sale rate for sales, by revenue per sale for money. *"I know how many sales I have, I multiply that by the revenue for that product, boom, there's an estimate."* CTR reference: the **Advanced Web Ranking** organic CTR study — *"a fantastic resource, because it changes by whether it's commercial intent or whether it's image intent."* Never skip the lead stage: *"there is always a lead stage."*

Search
volume

× organic
CTR curve

× conversion
rate

× sale
rate

× revenue
per sale

= forecast
revenue

9 Tier it into a layered proposal instead of one headline number.

"You never rank number one for all of the terms that you rank for." So present coverage bands: *"If I was in the top three for half of these terms with this conversion rate, the sale rate represents this much revenue. And then you take it down by half, say, if I ranked a quarter of these words in the top three, it could be this much."* The output is explicitly a sales document — *"a directional, layered goal and a proposal... this is the organic search potential of your market for this service or product."*

WORKED EXAMPLE — THE NEGATIVE LIST DECIDES THE CEILING

A client was *"obsessed with their brand phrase. They wanted to be a 'space cooler' instead of a space heater. They didn't want to be known as a swamp cooler, or a portable evaporative cooler, even though that's what people were searching for."* The red line was hard: *"do not call it a portable evaporative cooler, and if you call it a swamp cooler we will fire you."* The ceiling arrived on schedule — *"A year goes by, we're number one for 'space cooler', and they're getting this much traffic... I told them on the outset, there's only so much traffic that's going to show up for this."* The fix was **rank negative**, not abandoning the brand: *"Why don't I put on the homepage, 'not your mama's swamp cooler'... And we tripled their traffic in the first three months once we'd added those terms and phrases."*

Do not build this forecast on Google Search Console query data. Jeremy's own site: *"149 people visited, clicked to it. It gave me details for five of those clicks. So that's 3% of the data that's accurate."* BigQuery barely moved it — *"It took me half a day, and I've done this for 16 years... now I'm up to 12 clicks for that article."* Best case he has ever seen: *"I've never worked on a project where there was more than 70% of details."* Verdict: *"No statistician can work with 3% of the data."* Use GSC to sanity-check what you already rank for — never as the volume input to a revenue model.

CAUTIONARY NOTES

- **False positives sit at the top of the sort.** The biggest number in your proposal is the one most likely to be an impostor. Skipping the SERP pass is how it survives to the pitch.
- **Skipping client vetting fires you at month 12, not month 1.** No keyword tool knows about the lawsuit, the claim restriction or the banned phrase.
- **The forecast is directional and you must say so.** *"In a way, yes. In a sandbox type of way. So it's directional."* Every stage carries error, and they multiply.
- **Overlap does not cover topical or top-of-funnel.** *"TOFU, MOFU, BOFU — only down at the bottom does it overlap and it actually turn into money."* Run a separate clustering process for the top.
- **Do not turn the overlap list into ten more copies of what ranks.** *"I rank for this, they rank for that — I want to rank for what neither of us have touched."*

TIPS FOR EFFICIENCY

- **Budget the manual version honestly.** *"It took, you know, three hours for me to do it for a particular page."* Past a few runs, the exports are API-shaped.
- **Keep the overlap count as a permanent visible column.** It is the one number that separates this sheet from every other keyword export.
- **Batch the SERP checks top-down.** Catch the expensive errors first.
- **Ask "is there anything we are not allowed to say?" on the kickoff call.** One question surfaces legal, claim and brand red lines together.
- **Store CTR curve, conversion rate and sale rate as named assumptions at the top of the sheet** so they can be challenged and re-run.
- **The sheet is not the strategy.** *"You can have spreadsheets and spreadsheets of data, but it's like being a captain of a ship and you've got all of your charts but you never plot a course."*

Source: **Jeremy Rivera**, founder of SEO Arcade — SEO practitioner since 2007, and at the time of recording an SEO product lead at CopyPress. He described this as his own go-to keyword research process, built by hand in Google Sheets long before it became software. Every quote here is his.

Episode: Unscripted SEO Interview Podcast, hosted by **Mark A Preston** · recorded 28 October 2023.

Read the full interview: unscriptedseo.com/jeremy-rivera · **Read the SOP:** seoarcade.com/seo-sop-co-ranking-overlap-revenue-forecast

CTR data: advancedwebranking.com/free-seo-tools/google-organic-ctr · **More SOPs:** seoarcade.com/tag/seo-standard-operating-procedures/